most evident in the foreign policy conduct of former Prime Minister Manmohan Singh.[40] Even when Singh himself seemed entirely convinced of the logic of a strong Indo–US partnership, his weak authority resulted in a drift in bilateral relations, largely on account of differences with key ministers and the party high command. Modi experiences no such obstacles. He commands absolute authority within the BJP and in the lower house of Parliament. Given this unique alignment of party and parliamentary authority, Modi can be counted among a few Prime Ministers, including Jawaharlal Nehru and Indira Gandhi, who have enjoyed absolute command over foreign policy matters in India.

Explanations at the level of the individual and the state, however, must be complemented by developments at the structural level. The most prominent structural variable in the upward trajectory of Indo–US relations is the rise of China and its growing nexus with the Pakistani security establishment. For a long time, Indian decision-makers have been cognisant of the threat posed by China's meteoric rise, both economic and military. If the lingering border dispute is a permanent source of tension in Sino–Indian relations, China's attempts to thwart India's rise and accommodation in the international system generate apprehension among Indian elites. This has been most evident, most recently, in China's opposition to India's membership in the Nuclear Suppliers Group and, less conspicuously, in the United Nations Security Council. However, the most disconcerting development in the Sino–Indian equation has been Beijing's policy of using Pakistan as a proxy with greater vehemence than ever before.[41] China continues to assist Pakistan's nuclear and missile programmes and arms its military, which is primarily disposed to hostility towards New Delhi. It is now investing heavily in developing the strategic China Pakistan Economic Corridor (CPEC), parts of which go through the restive province of Balochistan and also